Part 4: Tie-Breaking Essay

These notes are not intended to be understood as a key for the Tie-Breaking Essay prompt; rather, they should serve the judge(s) as a presentation of critical ideas that might appear in an essay responding to the prompt.

Criteria for judging the Tie-Breaking Essay **SHOULD** include

the degree to which the instructions have been followed,

the quality of the critical insight offered in response to the selection,

the overall effectiveness of the written discussion, and

the grammatical correctness of the essay.

Note well that the quality of the contestant's critical insight is more important than the contestant's prose style. In short, the Literary Criticism contest is one that promotes the critical analysis of literature. The quality of the writing, which should never go unappreciated, does not trump evidence of critical analysis.

Critical Notes on Shelley's "[Tell me thou Star, whose wings of light]"

Literary concepts that MIGHT be used by the contestant in a discussion of these poems include

alliteration,
apostrophe,
diction (word choice),
imagery,
irony,
kenning,
metaphor,
rhetorical question,
rhyme scheme,
sigmatism,
simile, and
tone.

The observant student will notice that each stanza is an apostrophe addressing an element of nature. The speaker's perhaps wistful tone is marked by three introductory supplicatory imperatives, which, thus, characterizes the speaker's queries regarding several favored loci of respite: the Star's "cavern of night" (line 3), the Moon's "depth of night or day" (7), and the wind's "secret nest" (11).

The imagery of each stanzaic query suggests a longing for something similarly remote on the part of the speaker himself, the speaker's implied, unstated, requests pointing to something in the way of envy for the Star's, the Moon's, and the wind's being able to seclude themselves, at least at some point, from human awareness.

The young writer might make something of the receding distance associated with each element of nature to which he directs his question: the Star, the Moon, and the wind. The next possible site of isolation might be one within the reach of the speaker.